

Boeing B-17

Known as the “Flying Fortress,” the Boeing B-17 was an extraordinary fighting machine. It bristling with machine guns and could fly at an altitude of more than 30,000 ft (9,000 m). When in mass formation, it was capable of delivering a staggering tonnage of explosives. Since the B-17 was employed in large fleets, mass production was essential, and, for every B-17 shot down, American factories produced more than two.

FOR THE B-17'S CREW of 10, conditions were cramped and uncomfortable. The Flying Fortress was not pressurized and the effects of altitude sickness were highly unpleasant. The USAAF crews had to endure hours in freezing temperatures but always be alert and ready to battle the Luftwaffe's fighter force once over enemy territory. Nevertheless, the B-17 gained the abiding affection of those who flew in it, and the dependable Fortress became a symbol of America's

ability to take the war to Germany. Indeed, the B-17 was to take on the lion's share of the day bombing campaign.

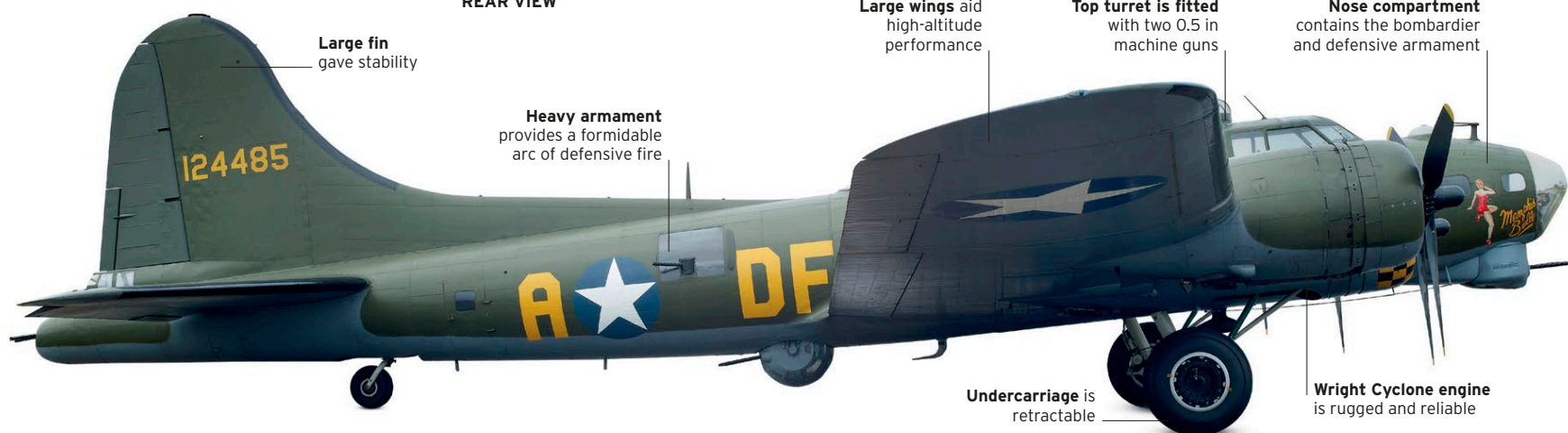
Although built in fewer numbers than its contemporary, Consolidated's B-24 Liberator, and despite its bomb load often being little more than that carried by the much smaller and faster de Havilland Mosquito, the B-17 was immensely strong and had a reputation for being able to take a great deal of punishment and still get its crew home.



FRONT VIEW



REAR VIEW



Large fin
gave stability

Heavy armament
provides a formidable
arc of defensive fire

Large wings aid
high-altitude
performance

Top turret is fitted
with two 0.5 in
machine guns

Nose compartment
contains the bombardier
and defensive armament

Undercarriage is
retractable

Wright Cyclone engine
is rugged and reliable

